

The Role of Education

Why do societies invest in schools? What should children learn, and how should they learn it? Is the purpose of education to transmit knowledge, to shape character, to prepare workers, or to transform society? These questions have been debated for centuries. Education is more than schooling. It is the process by which societies transmit knowledge, skills, values, and culture from one generation to the next. As a social science, education draws from psychology (how people learn), sociology (how schools function as social systems), philosophy (what is worth knowing), and economics (how education affects productivity and inequality). Understanding education means understanding not just classrooms but the relationship between education and society itself.

This reading material analyzes the goals of education, key educational theories and philosophies, methods of educational research, teaching by key stage in the Philippines, the relationship between education and society, and career pathways in education.

Part 1: Defining Education and Its Goals

Education is one of the most fundamental institutions in any society. It is the systematic process through which knowledge, skills, values, and cultural traditions are transmitted from one generation to the next. While formal education occurs in schools and universities, education also takes place informally through family, community, media, and life experience. As a social science, education studies not only teaching methods but also how educational systems shape and are shaped by social, economic, and political forces. Understanding the goals of education – from transmitting knowledge to fostering social mobility and nation-building – is essential for anyone who wishes to understand how societies reproduce themselves and change over time.

What Is Education?

Education is the systematic process of facilitating learning, acquiring knowledge, skills, values, and habits. While formal education occurs in schools, education also takes place informally through family, community, and media.

The Goals of Education

Different societies and educational philosophers have proposed different goals for education. Most education systems pursue multiple goals simultaneously.

Goal	Explanation
Transmission of knowledge	Passing down accumulated knowledge, history, and cultural heritage to the next generation
Development of critical thinking	Teaching students to analyze, evaluate, and create, not just memorize
Preparation for employment	Equipping students with skills and credentials needed for the workforce
Character and moral development	Shaping values, ethics, and responsible citizenship
Socialization	Integrating individuals into society; teaching norms, roles, and expectations
Social mobility	Providing pathways for individuals to improve their economic and social position
Social reproduction	Maintaining existing social structures and inequalities (critical perspective)
Personal fulfillment	Helping individuals discover and develop their unique potentials and interests

Goal	Explanation
Nation-building	Fostering national identity, loyalty, and shared purpose

The Philippine Educational Philosophy

The Philippine educational system is guided by the 1987 Constitution and the Enhanced Basic Education Act (RA 10533, K-12 law). Key goals include:

Goal	Source
Quality education accessible to all	Article XIV, 1987 Constitution
Development of patriotism and love of country	Article XIV, Section 3(2)
Inculcation of values and moral character	Article XIV, Section 3(2)
Preparation for productive citizenship	RA 10533 (K-12 law)
Holistic development of every learner	DepEd mission and vision

Part 2: Key Educational Theories and Philosophies

How people learn and what they should learn are questions that have occupied philosophers and educators for centuries. Educational theories explain the cognitive and behavioral processes by which learning occurs, drawing heavily from psychology. Educational philosophies, in contrast, prescribe what education should aim for – what knowledge is most worth having and what kind of citizens schools should produce. Together, theories and philosophies shape every aspect of schooling: curriculum design, teaching methods, assessment practices, and classroom management. By examining both the science of how people learn and the values that guide what is taught, one gains a complete picture of education as both a discipline and a practice.

Major Learning Theories (How People Learn)

Behaviorism

- *Key Thinkers:* Pavlov, Skinner, Thorndike
- *Core Idea:* Learning is a change in observable behavior caused by reinforcement (rewards) and punishment.
- *Application in Classroom:* Drill and practice; immediate feedback; rewards for correct answers; clear learning objectives

Cognitivism

- *Key Thinkers:* Piaget, Bruner, Vygotsky
- *Core Idea:* Learning involves mental processes: attention, memory, problem-solving, and organization of knowledge.
- *Application in Classroom:* Concept mapping; activating prior knowledge; teaching learning strategies; scaffolding

Constructivism

- *Key Thinkers:* Piaget, Dewey, Vygotsky
- *Core Idea:* Learners actively construct knowledge by connecting new information to existing mental frameworks.
- *Application in Classroom:* Hands-on activities; discovery learning; project-based learning; real-world problems

Social Learning Theory

- *Key Thinkers:* Albert Bandura
- *Core Idea:* Learning occurs through observation and imitation of models (teachers, peers, media).
- *Application in Classroom:* Modeling desired behaviors; using peer tutors; demonstrating skills before practice

Humanistic Learning Theory

- *Key Thinkers:* Carl Rogers, Abraham Maslow
- *Core Idea:* Learning is most effective when it addresses the whole person – cognitive, emotional, and social needs.
- *Application in Classroom:* Creating safe, supportive classroom climate; student choice in learning activities

Major Educational Philosophies (What Education Should Aim For)

Essentialism

- *Core Idea:* Education should teach essential knowledge and skills (reading, writing, math, history) needed by all citizens.
- *Role of Teacher:* Authority figure; transmitter of knowledge
- *Role of Student:* Passive receiver; must work hard and master basics
- *Curriculum Focus:* Core subjects; traditional content; back-to-basics

Perennialism

- *Core Idea:* Education should focus on universal, enduring ideas and great works (Great Books) that have stood the test of time.
- *Role of Teacher:* Guide through great texts; Socratic method
- *Role of Student:* Engage with timeless questions; develop reasoning
- *Curriculum Focus:* Philosophy, literature, history; classic texts

Progressivism

- *Core Idea:* Education should be child-centered, experiential, and relevant to real life. Learning by doing.
- *Role of Teacher:* Facilitator; co-learner; designer of experiences
- *Role of Student:* Active participant; problem-solver; collaborator
- *Curriculum Focus:* Integrated, thematic, project-based; student interests

Social Reconstructionism

- *Core Idea:* Education should address social problems and work to create a more just, equitable society.
- *Role of Teacher:* Agent of social change; activist
- *Role of Student:* Critical thinker; change agent
- *Curriculum Focus:* Social issues (inequality, environment, peace); action projects

Existentialism

- *Core Idea:* Education should help individuals discover their own meaning and authentic selves, not conform to external standards.
- *Role of Teacher:* Facilitator of self-discovery

- *Role of Student*: Chooser; creator of own meaning
- *Curriculum Focus*: Arts, humanities, philosophy; student-directed

Pragmatism

- *Core Idea*: Education should prepare students for practical, effective participation in democratic society.
- *Role of Teacher*: Problem-poser; guide in inquiry
- *Role of Student*: Inquirer; experimenter
- *Curriculum Focus*: Real-world problems; interdisciplinary

Philippine Educational Philosophy Context

Influences	Description
American colonial legacy	English as medium; public school system; progressive education influences
Japanese occupation (brief)	Emphasis on Japanese language and culture; Asian values
Post-colonial nationalism	Filipino language and culture; history; national identity
K-12 reform (2013)	Alignment with international standards; emphasis on holistic development and career readiness
Indigenization	Adapting curricula to local cultural contexts; integrating indigenous knowledge systems

Part 3: Methods of Educational Research

Education is not merely a matter of tradition or intuition. Effective teaching and sound educational policy should be grounded in evidence. Educational research uses systematic,

scientific methods to study teaching, learning, schools, and educational policies. Researchers may ask whether a new reading program improves literacy, how class size affects student achievement, or what parents think about the K-12 curriculum. By employing methods such as experiments, case studies, surveys, and action research, educational researchers generate knowledge that helps teachers improve their practice and policymakers make informed decisions.

Major Research Methods in Education

Method	Description	Example Question
Experimental research	Manipulating teaching method to measure effect on learning outcomes	Does cooperative learning improve test scores compared to lecture?
Quasi-experimental	Similar to experiment but without random assignment	Does a new reading program improve literacy in existing classrooms?
Correlational research	Measuring relationships between educational variables	Is there a relationship between class size and student achievement?
Case study	In-depth study of a single classroom, school, or program	How does a particular school implement inclusive education for students with disabilities?
Ethnography	Extended observation of educational settings to understand culture	What are the informal norms and values transmitted in a school's "hidden curriculum"?
Action research	Teachers conducting research in their own classrooms to improve practice	How can I reduce disruptive behavior in my Grade 5 class?

Survey research	Collecting data from large samples of students, teachers, or schools	What are parents' attitudes toward the K-12 program?
Longitudinal research	Following the same students over years or decades	How do early childhood experiences affect high school graduation rates?

Key Concepts in Educational Research

Concept	Explanation
Qualitative research	Focuses on meaning, experience, and context; uses interviews, observation, text analysis
Quantitative research	Focuses on measurement, numbers, and statistics; uses tests, surveys, experiments
Mixed methods	Combines qualitative and quantitative approaches
Evidence-based practice	Teaching methods and policies supported by research, not just tradition or opinion
Assessment	Measuring student learning through tests, portfolios, observations, and performance tasks

Part 4: Teaching by Key Stage in the Philippines

The Philippine basic education system underwent a major reform with the implementation of the K-12 program in 2013. This reform organized the curriculum into four distinct key stages, each corresponding to specific grade levels and developmental characteristics of learners. A key stage is a grouping of grade levels that share similar learning goals, developmental needs, and appropriate teaching approaches. From Kindergarten to Grade 3,

children learn best through play and hands-on activities, while Senior High School students specialize through academic or technical-vocational tracks. Understanding these key stages helps teachers select age-appropriate methods and helps policymakers design curricula that meet learners where they are.

Overview of Key Stages

Key Stage	Grade Levels	Typical Age Range	Description
Key Stage 1 (KS1)	Kindergarten to Grade 3	5 to 8 years old	Foundational literacy and numeracy; learning through play and exploration
Key Stage 2 (KS2)	Grades 4 to 6	9 to 11 years old	Building basic competencies; introduction to subject-specific concepts
Key Stage 3 (KS3)	Grades 7 to 10 (Junior High School)	12 to 15 years old	Deeper disciplinary knowledge; preparation for Senior High School tracks
Key Stage 4 (KS4)	Grades 11 to 12 (Senior High School)	16 to 18 years old	Specialization through tracks (Academic, Technical-Vocational-Livelihood, Sports, Arts and Design)

Teaching Approaches by Key Stage

Key Stage	Developmental Focus	Teaching Approaches
KS1	Developing basic skills; short attention span; concrete thinking	Play-based; hands-on activities; songs and games; explicit instruction in reading and math

Key Stage	Developmental Focus	Teaching Approaches
KS2	Increasing independence; ability to work in groups; emerging abstract thinking	Collaborative learning; guided discovery; project-based learning; integration of subjects
KS3	Abstract thinking develops; identity formation; peer relationships important	Inquiry-based learning; Socratic discussion; research projects; connections to real-world issues
KS4	Career preparation; specialization; critical thinking for complex problems	Track-specific instruction; work immersion (TVL track); research projects (Academic track); portfolio development

The Senior High School Tracks

Track	Strands	Career Pathways
Academic	ABM (Accountancy, Business, Management); STEM (Science, Technology, Engineering, Math); HUMSS (Humanities and Social Sciences); GAS (General Academic)	College preparation in specific fields
Technical-Vocational-Livelihood (TVL)	Agri-fishery; Home Economics; Industrial Arts; Information and Communications Technology (ICT)	Immediate employment; entrepreneurship; TESDA certification
Sports	Sports science; coaching; fitness	College or employment in sports-related fields
Arts and Design	Visual arts; performing arts; creative writing	College or employment in creative industries

Part 5: The Relationship Between Education and Society

Education does not exist in a vacuum. It both shapes and is shaped by society. Understanding this relationship is central to education as a social science.

How Education Affects Society

Effect	Explanation
Socialization	Schools teach norms, values, and expected behaviors (e.g., punctuality, respect for authority, competition)
Human capital development	Education increases knowledge and skills, making workers more productive and innovative
Social mobility	Education provides pathways for individuals from disadvantaged backgrounds to improve their economic position
Cultural preservation	Schools transmit language, history, literature, and cultural traditions
Nation-building	Education fosters national identity, loyalty, and shared values
Social change	Education can challenge unjust norms and prepare students to address social problems

How Society Affects Education

Effect	Explanation
Economic conditions	Funding for schools depends on economic growth and government budget priorities

Effect	Explanation
Social inequality	Students from wealthier families have access to better resources, tutoring, and schools
Cultural values	What is taught (curriculum) and how (pedagogy) reflects dominant cultural values
Political ideologies	Governments influence curriculum, textbook content, and teacher training
Labor market demands	Schools adjust programs to prepare students for available jobs
Technology	Digital tools change how teaching and learning occur

Key Sociological Concepts in Education

Concept	Explanation
Hidden curriculum	The unofficial, implicit lessons taught in schools (obedience, competition, punctuality)
Cultural capital	The knowledge, skills, and cultural assets (e.g., familiarity with "high culture") that advantage some students
Social reproduction	The tendency of schools to reproduce existing social inequalities across generations
Credentialism	The increasing demand for formal educational credentials even for jobs that do not require them
Tracking / streaming	Separating students into different educational paths (e.g., Academic vs. TVL) which can perpetuate inequality

Concept	Explanation
School segregation	Separation of students by race, class, or other characteristics across different schools

Part 6: Career Pathways in Education

Education offers diverse career opportunities beyond classroom teaching. The profession is regulated in the Philippines by the Professional Regulation Commission (PRC) through the Licensure Examination for Teachers (LET).

Major Career Pathways

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks	Licensure Required
Classroom Teacher (Elementary)	Public or private elementary schools	Lesson planning; instruction; assessment; classroom management; parent communication	LET (Licensure Examination for Teachers)
Classroom Teacher (Secondary)	Public or private high schools	Subject-specific teaching (e.g., Math, Science, English, Filipino, Social Studies)	LET (subject-specific)
Senior High School Teacher	Public or private SHS	Teaching specialized subjects within tracks (Academic, TVL, Sports, Arts)	LET (relevant specialization)

Special Education Teacher	SPED centers, inclusive schools	Adapting curriculum for students with disabilities; individualized instruction	LET plus SPED training
School Administrator	Schools (principal, head teacher, superintendent)	School leadership; teacher supervision; curriculum implementation; budget management	LET plus administrative experience and qualifications
Curriculum Developer	DepEd, private schools, publishing companies	Designing curricula; writing learning materials; aligning with national standards	LET or relevant advanced degree
Guidance Counselor	Schools	Academic and career guidance; social-emotional support for students	Guidance Counselor Licensure (RA 9258)
Educational Researcher	Universities, research institutes, DepEd	Studying teaching methods, learning outcomes, educational policies	Advanced degree (Master's or PhD)
Instructional Designer	Corporations, online learning platforms	Designing training materials; developing e-learning courses	May not require LET

Education Policy Analyst	Government agencies (DepEd, CHED, Congressional committees), think tanks	Analyzing education policies; writing policy briefs; legislative research	Advanced degree in education or public policy
Teacher Educator (College Professor)	Colleges of education, universities	Training future teachers; supervising student teachers; research	LET plus Master's or PhD
Corporate Trainer	Private companies	Training employees in skills; professional development programs	May not require LET
Early Childhood Educator	Daycare centers, preschools	Teaching children aged 0-5; developmental activities	ECCD certificate or relevant training

The Licensure Examination for Teachers (LET) in the Philippines

Aspect	Details
Regulatory body	Professional Regulation Commission (PRC) and Board for Professional Teachers
Levels	Elementary Level (Bachelor of Elementary Education) and Secondary Level (Bachelor of Secondary Education with major)
Coverage	General Education (20%), Professional Education (40%), Major Field (40%)
Passing rate	Typically 70% or higher (averaged across subjects, with no score below 50%)

Demand for Teachers in the Philippines

Factor	Explanation
Growing student population	Continued need for teachers at elementary and secondary levels
K-12 implementation	Increased demand for Senior High School teachers, especially for TVL specializations
International demand	Filipino teachers are recruited internationally (USA, Middle East, Thailand, etc.)
Teacher shortages in specific areas	Shortages in Math, Science, English, Special Education, and TVL specializations

Key Terms

Term	Definition
Education	The systematic process of facilitating learning, acquiring knowledge, skills, values, and habits
Essentialism	Educational philosophy emphasizing core knowledge and skills
Progressivism	Educational philosophy emphasizing child-centered, experiential learning
Constructivism	Learning theory: learners actively construct knowledge, not passively receive it
Hidden curriculum	Unofficial, implicit lessons taught in schools (obedience, competition, punctuality)
Cultural capital	Knowledge and assets that advantage some students in educational systems
Social reproduction	Tendency of schools to reproduce existing social inequalities
Key stage	A grouping of grade levels with distinct developmental and learning goals
K-12 program	The Philippine basic education system: Kindergarten + 12 years (Grades 1-12)
LET (Licensure Examination for Teachers)	Licensure exam required to teach in Philippine public schools and most private schools

Review Questions

1. Define education as a social science. What are four goals of education?

2. Complete the following table comparing three learning theories:

Theory	Key Thinker	Core Idea	Classroom Application
Behaviorism			
Cognitivism			
Constructivism			

3. Choose two educational philosophies (e.g., Essentialism, Progressivism, Social Reconstructionism). For each, describe the role of the teacher, the role of the student, and the curriculum focus.

4. What is action research in education? How is it different from experimental research?

5. Describe the four key stages in the Philippine K-12 curriculum. For each key stage, state the grade levels, typical age range, and one teaching approach appropriate for that stage.

6. What are the four tracks in Senior High School? Provide two strands or examples under each track.

7. Explain two ways education affects society and two ways society affects education.

8. What is the "hidden curriculum"? Provide two examples of hidden curriculum lessons that schools may teach implicitly.

9. List three career pathways in education (other than classroom teacher). For each, state the work setting and whether licensure (LET) is required.

10. Application question: A researcher wants to study whether the new Mother Tongue-Based Multilingual Education (MTB-MLE) policy in the Philippines improves reading comprehension in Grade 1 students compared to traditional instruction. Design a research study. What research method would you use (experimental, quasi-experimental, correlational, case study, action research)? Who would your participants be? What data would you collect?